incommensurate with the premier's private remarks. From India's perspective, there were other discrepancies in Chinese behaviour. While Zhou seemed reassuring in both 1954 and 1956–57, China was proceeding with road building in the western sector, possibly in contested ground. Beginning sometime in 1951, China had begun to build a highway from Xinjiang to Tibet through Aksai Chin to move its forces and supplies to the restive province. Indian intelligence may have obtained information on the road as early as that year, but by May 1956 Delhi had clear enough evidence of its existence – in September 1957, China's *People's Daily* published a map showing the road, removing all doubt.[18]

The contradictions and inconsistencies in China's stand were now more or less at an end. When Indian patrols confirmed the existence of the road, India protested to China. As India and China exchanged diplomatic notes on the road, Nehru, aroused by developments in Aksai Chin, wrote to Zhou in December 1958. Focusing on the eastern sector (probably because the diplomats were already in conversation on the western sector), he reminded Zhou that China had said it would recognize the McMahon Line. Zhou's reply in January 1959 was categorical: a properly defined border with India did not exist, and the McMahon Line accepted by Tibetan representatives in 1914 at the Simla conference with British India was improperly drawn. Nevertheless, China would take 'a realistic attitude'. As before, Zhou asked for time to deal with the matter. On the western sector, too, he expressed China's clear disagreement, asking that both sides stick with the status quo pending resolution of their differences.[19] In reply, in March 1959, Nehru accepted that the border had not been altogether delineated between India and China, but he argued that by and large the line went along the watershed. In the western sector, there were nineteenth-century imperial treaties regulating the borderlands, in the middle sector there were traditional norms, and in the eastern sector there was the McMahon Line which had not been challenged until then by Chinese authorities. India agreed in any case to avoid unilateral action.[20]

Although we do not have detailed studies of China's views on Indian policy in this period, a thought-experiment suggests Beijing could well have